



ILLUSTRATION BY RAJ VERMA

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It will be appropriate if the Union government finds the required funds for Azadpur under the Prime Minister Dhan-Dhaanya Krishi Yojana (announced by the Finance Minister in her Budget speech on February 1, 2025) for creating modern facilities of global standards in

the markets of national importance, beginning with Azadpur. The states should then be persuaded to match the facilities in their bigger APMCs.

RULES NOT NOTIFIED

Agriculture marketing reforms have been on the national agenda since 2003, when a model “State Agricultural Produce Marketing (Development & Regulation) Act, 2003” was circulated to the states. Several

states amended their APMC Acts in accordance with the model law. However, only a few have notified the rules. For example, Andhra Pradesh, Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Gujarat, Haryana, Jharkhand, Karnataka, Manipur, Meghalaya, Nagaland, Tamil Nadu, Telangana, Tripura, and Uttar Pradesh have enacted a provision to include warehouses as deemed market yards, but only four states, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Telangana and Uttar Pradesh, have notified the rules. A similar situation exists for other reforms.

E-NAM'S HIGH POTENTIAL

In 2015-16, the Ministry of Agriculture had taken up a proposal to develop a “Unified Market” for agriculture produce; the e-National Agriculture Market (e-NAM) was launched. This was to enable the development of a pan-Indian market to enable buyers from across the country to bid for agricultural produce in any APMC linked to e-NAM. The idea was to enable farmers to get the best price discovery in competitive, online bidding. The progress on this front has been below par. To make it a success, the Union government needs to enact a law for inter-state secondary trade (primary trade is governed by the respective APMC Acts).

HARD PUSH NEEDED

The Additional Secretary in the Ministry of Agriculture dealing with the National Policy Framework 2024 was transferred recently. It can be hoped that the Minister of Agriculture, Shivraj Singh Chouhan, who has a long experience as Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister, will provide the much-needed direction and push to the reform of marketing laws by the states. **BT**

Views are personal